



BARRY CHIN/GLOBE STAFF

New England Patriots wide receiver Kayshon Boutte hauled in a touchdown pass during the fourth quarter in Foxborough.

An ugly win gives Patriots a beautiful shot at Super Bowl

DAN SHAUGHNESSY

FOXBOROUGH — Playing for three-plus hours in what we like to call “wintry mix,” the Patriots beat the dome-home Houston Texans, 28-16, at Gillette on Sunday and will face the top-seeded Denver Broncos in the AFC Championship game at Mile High next weekend.

Pretty incredible. After back-to-back four-win seasons, these “pinch-me, it-can’t-be-true” Pats have an opportunity to return to the Super Bowl just six seasons after Tom Brady bolted for Tampa, and a mere two years after Bill

Belichick was fired by Bob Kraft. “It wasn’t pretty,” said coach Mike Vrabel. “I know there’s times when it doesn’t look great, but we know we’re going against a great defense.” With the masterful Vrabel and possible MVP in quarterback Drake Maye, the Pats no doubt will have a lot of good moments in the next few years, but they are unlikely to ever have a better path to another Super Bowl appearance. At this hour, the only quarterback standing between New England and the Super Bowl is Bronco backup Jarrett Stidham — a former Tom Brady clipboard holder who has not thrown a pass in an NFL game since

2023. Unbelievable. After a 14-3 cupcake-schedule regular season, then manhandling the 11-5 Chargers and 12-5 Texans in back-to-back weekend beatdowns at the Razor, New England’s Fortunate Sons will face Stidham for the AFC Championship. Denver’s starter, Bo Nix, broke his ankle Saturday in the closing seconds of its overtime win over the Bills. Perfect. Like Garrett Crochet strikeout victims, blades of grass under your Toro Recycler, and fictional targets of Roland the Headless Thompson Gunner, many of the dangerous gunslingers of the NFL have fallen down and

SHAUGHNESSY, Page C5

A gloom lingers in murder of professor

By Brian MacQuarrie

GLOBE STAFF

BROOKLINE — The flowers are gone from the steps of the condominium where slain MIT professor Nuno F.G. Loureiro lived with his family. His quiet neighborhood near Coolidge Corner has reverted to its usual, predictable rhythms one month after Loureiro, a father of three, was fatally shot in the entryway to the building. G i b b s Street now is devoid of police and news media, but Loureiro’s shooting on Dec. 15, by the same man who killed two Brown University students two days before, continues to reverberate throughout Brookline.

“We’re still in pain, and I don’t feel anything except a blanket of sadness still,” said Jay Konieczka, a neighbor and close friend of Loureiro’s. “I don’t think there’s been much healing. It’s too soon. Nuno has left just a massive hole in our community.” The loss of Loureiro, an acclaimed physicist who led MIT’s

LOUREIRO, Page A10

Striking oil, with a tasty twist

Some see a local culinary industry from hickory tree

By Amanda Gokee

GLOBE STAFF

What if New England trees could produce a culinary oil on par with olive oil? What if they already do — except practically no one knows it? Local producers and foresters are

working to put homegrown hickory oil on the map. Some experts even claim the oil, pressed from hickory nuts, could become the region’s next maple syrup. Bitternut hickory trees are abundant along the East Coast and parts of the Midwest, and the trees are expected to expand into new territory amid climate change. Proponents say that their oil is as healthy as olive oil and that its nutty, buttery taste is even better. Good luck getting your hands on

a bottle of it. The oil is produced in tiny quantities and is difficult to find in stores. Its handful of small-scale producers struggle to keep the oil in stock. “It’s as if people in the Mediterranean region didn’t know you could use olives,” said Samuel Thayer, a Wisconsin-based pioneer of the hickory oil cottage industry and a wild food expert. “We have an equivalent to the olive here. It’s the best temperate,

HICKORY, Page A7



PARAS GRIFFIN/GETTY IMAGES

AT A TABLE OF BROTHERHOOD

Anika Noni Rose and Aldis Hodge spoke at the 2026 MLK Jr. Beloved Community Awards in Atlanta Saturday. The annual event honors community leaders and businesses. In Boston, organizers are gearing up for events with more of a sense of urgency. B1.

Hearings resurface drug lab scandal

Years after chemist’s trial, new evidence brings fresh scrutiny to even more cases

By Sean Cotter

GLOBE STAFF

WOBURN — More than a decade ago, revelations that a chemist had falsified test results at the Hinton state drug lab rocked the justice system. Multiple investigations found disarray within the lab, leading authorities to shutter the facility and dismiss thousands of cases in a scandal that drew national attention and even spawned a noted documentary. But even as authorities have since relocated to a new State Police-run testing lab, the issue is far from over.

The Hinton drug lab scandal has resurfaced. In March, hearings with potentially wide-ranging ramifications are scheduled to play out over multiple weeks in Middlesex Superior Court, and they could set the groundwork for hundreds of thousands of convictions to be thrown out. At issue is how far problems at the lab spread beyond the chemist Annie Dookhan, who for years was labeled the “sole bad actor” who willfully tampered with drug samples.

Court filings from recent years show the state office of the inspector general referred at least four other Hinton lab employees for criminal prosecution to the attorney general’s office in the years following Dookhan’s arrest. None was ever criminally charged, and the referrals remained secret until Middlesex prosecutors found them in IOG documents ordered turned over in 2022. Per judicial ethics rules, the prosecutors were required to disclose the referrals.

The hearings in Woburn involve seven drug

DRUG LAB, Page A10

Europe fears ‘spiral’ over Greenland

Leaders say Trump’s threats could harm diplomacy

By Stefanie Dazio, Jill Lawless, and Emma Burrows

ASSOCIATED PRESS

BERLIN — The eight European countries targeted by President Trump for a 10 percent tariff for opposing American control of Greenland blasted the move Sunday, warning that his threats “undermine transatlantic relations and risk a dangerous downward spiral.”

The joint statement by some of America’s closest allies signaled a possible turning point in the recent tensions over sovereignty and security nearly 24 hours after Trump’s threat.

It was also the most forceful rebuke of Trump from the European allies since he returned to the White House almost a year ago. In recent months, Europeans have mostly opted for diplomacy and flattery around him, even when seeking an end to the war in Ukraine. Sunday’s statement, as well as some European countries sending troops to Greenland for a Danish military training exercise, appeared to be a step away from that strategy.

The unusually strong joint statement from Denmark, Norway, Sweden, France, Germany, the United Kingdom, the Netherlands, and Finland said troops sent to Greenland for operation “Arctic Endurance” pose “no threat to anyone.”

Danish Foreign Minister Lars Løkke Rasmussen told reporters in Oslo that a dialogue was opened with the United States last week and “we will not give up on that. ... So we will stay on track — unless the US decides differently.”

Added Norwegian Foreign Minister Espen Barth Eide at the same news conference: “We will

GREENLAND, Page A6

Not quite a dream forecast

Monday: Early snow, clouds. High 35-40, low 17-22.
Tuesday: Sunny, colder. High 24-29, low 12-17
Weather and comics, **D4-5**.
Obituaries, **B6**.



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Frustration was evident at a forum between Boston police and the civilian group charged with overseeing it. B1.

The Syrian government and a Kurdish-led militia agreed to a cease-fire and to merge the militia fully into the national

forces. **A3.**

A statewide program gives detained youths vocational skills such as cutting hair. D1.

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